Navigating Your First Week: Onboarding and Introductions in IT

CEFR: B1 | 90-min online class Vocab -> Useful Sentences -> Reading -> Dialogue -> Discussion

Learning Objectives

By the end of this 90-minute lesson, learners will be able to: Discuss the onboarding process and initial tasks in a new IT role. Introduce themselves and their experience to new colleagues effectively. Identify and use key vocabulary related to setting up a new work environment. Employ useful phrases for asking questions and offering information during onboarding. Engage in conversations about their first days at a new company.

Warmer (5 minutes)

Teacher asks: "What is one thing you usually do on your first day at a new job?" or "What do you look forward to most when starting somewhere new?" Activity: Learners share their answers briefly in pairs or small groups (breakout rooms) for 2 minutes. The teacher then asks 2-3 learners to share with the whole class.

Vocabulary Focus (15 minutes)

1. onboard (v) /ɒn.bɔːrd/

Definition: To help a new employee join a company and learn about their job.

Example: "The HR team will onboard all new hires next Monday."

2. provision (v) /prəˈvɪʒ.ən/

Definition: To give someone something they need, especially access or resources for their work.

Example: "IT needs to provision the new laptop and software for the new developer."

3. configure (v) /ˈkɒn.fɪg.ər/

Definition: To set up something, like software or hardware, with specific settings to make it work correctly.

Example: "I spent my first day trying to configure my development environment."

4. familiarize (v) /fəˈmɪl.i.ə.raɪz/

Definition: To learn about something or to help someone learn about something.

Example: "I need to familiarize myself with the team's project management tool."

5. allocate (v) /ˈæl.ə.keɪt/

Definition: To give a share of something, like tasks or resources, to a person or group.

Example: "The team lead will allocate specific tasks to the new members."

6. escalate (v) /ˈes.kə.leɪt/

Definition: To make a problem or issue more serious, or to send it to a person who can deal with higher-level problems.

Example: "If you can't fix the network issue, you should escalate it to the IT support manager."

7. repository (n) /rɪˈpɒz.ɪ.tər.i/

Definition: A central place where a set of files, especially code, is stored and maintained. (Used in version control systems like Git.)

Example: "Please clone the main project repository to get started."

8. credentials (n) /krɪˈden.ʃəlz/

Definition: Information such as a username and password used to prove one's identity to gain access to a system or service.

Example: "Make sure you have your login credentials for all development tools."

Language Focus: Useful Sentences (10 minutes)

Here are 5 useful sentence structures for introducing oneself and navigating onboarding:

1. **"I'm excited to be joining the team as a [Your Role]."**

* **Usage:** To express enthusiasm and state your position.

* **Example:** "I'm excited to be joining the team as a Backend Developer."

2. **"My main focus in the first few weeks will be to [Task/Goal]."**

* **Usage:** To describe your initial priorities.

* **Example:** "My main focus in the first few weeks will be to understand the existing codebase."

3. **"Could you please show me how to [Action/Process]?"**

* **Usage:** To politely ask for help or guidance on a specific process.

* **Example:** "Could you please show me how to commit changes to the repository?"

4. **"I'm looking forward to learning about [Topic/System]."**

* **Usage:** To express eagerness to gain knowledge on a specific area.

* **Example:** "I'm looking forward to learning about the new microservices architecture."

5. **"Is there anything specific I should know about [Team/Project]?"**

* **Usage:** To ask for important details or context about a team or project.

* **Example:** "Is there anything specific I should know about the current project deadlines?"

Main Activities (45 minutes)

Reading (10 minutes)

A New Developer's First Week

Starting a new IT job can be both exciting and challenging. When a new hire arrives, the HR and IT teams work together to onboard them smoothly. First, IT needs to provision all the necessary hardware, like a laptop, and software licenses. The new developer then needs to configure their development environment, which often involves installing various tools and setting up specific parameters. It's important for them to familiarize themselves with the company's code standards and project documentation.

Once the basic setup is done, the team lead will often allocate initial tasks. These tasks might include getting access to the code repository and ensuring their credentials are correctly set up. Throughout this process, new employees often need to ensure their access rights are correct for different systems. If any technical issues come up that they can't solve, they know they can escalate the problem to a more experienced colleague or support team. A good onboarding process makes sure the new developer feels welcomed and ready to contribute quickly.

Comprehension Questions:

1. What are the first two things IT needs to do for a new developer?

Answer: IT needs to provision all the necessary hardware, like a laptop, and software licenses.

2. What is important for a new developer to familiarize themselves with?

Answer: It's important for them to familiarize themselves with the company's code standards and project documentation.

3. What should a new developer do if they face a technical issue they can't resolve?

Answer: They should escalate the problem to a more experienced colleague or support team.

Dialogue (15 minutes)

Team Members: Mark (Team Lead), Sarah (New Frontend Developer), Alex (Senior Developer)

Mark: "Alright everyone, before we kick off our stand-up, I'd like to introduce Sarah, our new Frontend Developer. Sarah, welcome to the team! We're all excited to have you."

Sarah: "Hi everyone! Thanks, Mark. I'm excited to be joining the team as a Frontend Developer. Everyone's been so welcoming, and the onboarding process has been quite efficient. I've already managed to configure my main development environment."

Alex: "That's great, Sarah! If you need anything regarding access or setting up your local repository, just let me know. We usually try to provision all necessary software and accounts beforehand."

Sarah: "Thanks, Alex, I appreciate that! I've mostly got my credentials sorted now. My main focus in the first few weeks will be to familiarize myself with the existing codebase and our design system."

Mark: "Excellent. We'll allocate your first few tasks later today, mostly around getting you familiar with some of our smaller components."

Sarah: "And speaking of familiar, I'm looking forward to learning about the current project's UI/UX challenges. Also, is there anything specific I should know about the team's daily stand-up process?"

Alex: "Our stand-ups are pretty straightforward, usually 15 minutes. We share what we did yesterday, what we plan today, and any blockers. If you encounter a significant technical blocker you can't solve, remember to escalate it early."

Sarah: "Got it. Could you please show me how to submit a pull request once I have some changes ready?"

Mark: "Of course, we can pair on that later this week. Again, welcome, Sarah!"

Activity:

1. **Listen & Read:** Teacher plays or reads the dialogue aloud. Learners follow along.
2. **Role-play (Pairs):** Learners are put into pairs (breakout rooms). They take turns role-playing Sarah and Mark/Alex. Encourage them to focus on pronunciation and intonation, and using the target vocabulary and phrases naturally. (8 minutes)

Feedback:

- Bring learners back.
- Ask if they noticed the new words or phrases being used.
- Address any pronunciation difficulties.

Discussion (20 minutes)

Teacher facilitates a group discussion using the following questions. Encourage learners to use the new vocabulary and sentence structures.

Activity:

1. **Group Discussion:** Teacher leads a whole-class discussion, encouraging all learners to participate. (15 minutes)
2. **Peer Feedback:** Ask learners to listen to each other and identify instances where their classmates used the new vocabulary or phrases. (5 minutes)

Discussion Questions:

1. Imagine you are a new developer. Which of the onboarding steps (e.g., provisioning, configuring, familiarizing) do you think is most important for you? Why?
2. Have you ever had to escalate a problem during your first days at a new job? What happened?
3. What would you typically allocate your time to in your very first week at a new company?
4. Using some of the useful sentences, introduce yourself and say what you would focus on in your first weeks at a new IT company.

Wrap-Up (5 minutes)

Review: Briefly recap the 8 vocabulary words and 5 useful sentences. Quick Check: Ask learners to share one new word or phrase they learned today that they will try to use in their daily work. Encouragement: Praise learners for their participation and effort.

Homework (Optional)

1. Write a Paragraph: Write a short paragraph (5-7 sentences) about your ideal onboarding experience at an IT company. Try to use at least 3 of the new vocabulary words and 2 of the useful sentences from today's lesson. 2. Prepare a Short Talk: Prepare a 1-minute talk introducing yourself as a new IT professional. Include your role, what you are excited about, and one question you might ask on your first day. Be ready to share it at the beginning of the next lesson.